

Saudi Arabia, where he had been in exile since 2000 under a—until recently—secret agreement. The agreement had allowed him, in effect, to escape a life-term prison sentence for “hijacking” and endangering an airborne commercial airliner—carrying General Musharraf whom he had attempted to sack as army chief—in return for a promise to stay away from the country and its politics for 10 years. He had received an unexpected shot in the arm from a Supreme Court judgment in August this year that affirmed his fundamental right as a Pakistani citizen to return to his country, despite the Pakistani Government’s plea that this would violate the terms of the agreement he had signed.

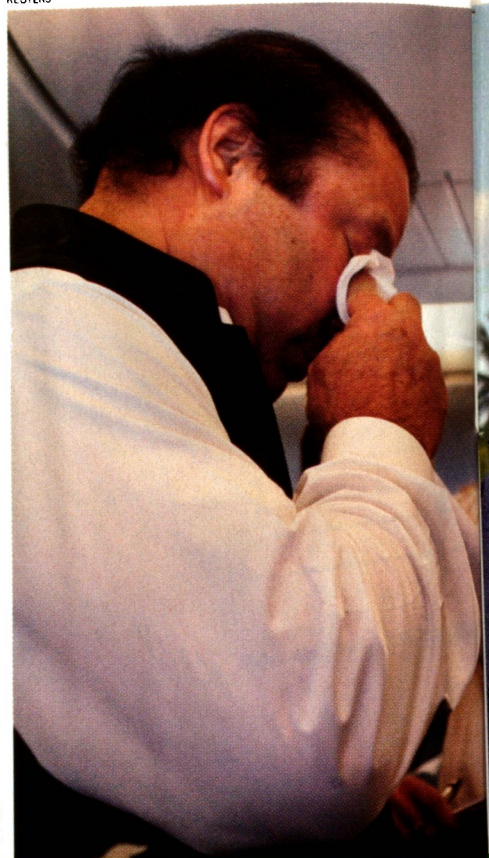
Buoyed by the new-found assertiveness of the Supreme Court, Sharif had probably under-estimated General Musharraf’s ability and resolve to keep him away. It seems he had also been goaded by his supporters within Pakistan to take the plunge, without much planning. From eye-witness accounts, Sharif and supporters

But even before he took off from Heathrow, there had been ominous signs of the Pakistani Government’s intentions. Sharif had been stunned to see on television the images of a most unusual press conference that took place in Islamabad a day before his departure from London. Saudi intelligence chief Prince Muqrin bin Abdul Aziz had landed in the Pakistani capital along with Saad Hariri—the son of the assassinated former Lebanese premier and business tycoon Rafik Hariri whom Sharif was close to—and after meeting General Musharraf, had held a press conference on the lawns of the President’s camp office.

In it, the two Arab visitors had shown the press an agreement signed by Sharif and his brother Shahbaz—former chief minister of Punjab—with Saudi King Abdullah bin Abdul Aziz and affirmed that Hariri had played a role in brokering it. Even more ominously, they had tersely warned Sharif to honour it.

The Sharif brothers—who until then had flat out denied any such

REUTERS



AN ADVERSE JUDGMENT FROM THE SUPREME COURT REGARDING THE DEPORTATION

had chalked out no action plan as to what he would do once he landed back in Pakistan. He had banked heavily on the scores of journalists accompanying him to shield him even as his party organised a ‘spectacle’ to embarrass the Musharraf Government for the world media.

Optimistically, Sharif had been led to believe that the worst the Government would do was arrest him, turning him into a political martyr. The Government did go through the whole charade of serving arrest warrants on him inside the airport’s VIP lounge, on charges of money laundering related to one of his business concerns. “But the ruthless efficiency with which he was eventually deported had a kind of brutal choreography to it,” says Mohammed Hanif, the head of BBC’s South Asian service. “The commandos around him suddenly formed a ring around him and despite the efforts of his supporters to intervene, simply whisked him away,” says Hanif. According to his family, Sharif may have been led to believe he was being taken to jail in Karachi or Quetta.

agreement and had even discounted an earlier official Saudi statement referring to it as concocted—were reduced to ruing “Musharraf’s attempts to drag a brotherly Islamic country into Pakistan’s internal affairs”. Eventually, Sharif held a press conference in London on September 8 in which he admitted the existence of the agreement, but bizarrely claimed that while he had signed the 10-year promise, he had been told by Hariri that it “should be considered as only for five years”. Government spokespersons in Islamabad gleefully ridiculed this late admission.

The Sharif brothers obviously did consider the worst case scenario, despite their optimism that the Pakistan Government would not blatantly go against the Supreme Court judgment. At the last minute before boarding the flight in London, Sharif announced that Shahbaz would stay back in the UK “to manage party affairs” in case something happened to him. Arrest warrants for Shahbaz had already been issued earlier in the week by an anti-terrorism court in Lahore in a

case accusing him of extra-judicial killings while he was chief minister.

For its part, the Pakistani Government has been sticking to its stand that Sharif was allowed back into the country as per the Supreme Court ruling but was presented with a choice upon his arrival—to return to Saudi Arabia under the old agreement or face arrest and jail. According to information minister Mohammad Ali Durrani, he chose the former. “All the legal formalities were complied with,” said Durrani. Sharif’s party, the Pakistan Muslim League (PML-N), has filed a contempt of court petition in the Supreme Court challenging this interpretation of events and it remains to be seen how the Government will defend itself.

While most people do not believe the Government’s line, it may be difficult to prove otherwise with Sharif sequestered away in Jeddah. The Government could also claim that having received an official request for extradition from a strategically important friendly state, it had to comply for reasons of national security and that Sharif was no longer in its jurisdiction.